Airbus

The Next Chapter of the Airbus Story

Airbus is entering a new phase of its investment case. The focus is shifting from ramp-up execution to medium-term earnings power, cash generation and shareholder returns as highlighted by its €12-13bn EBIT target in 2029 and unexpected €5bn buyback.

AIR.PA/AIR FP	OVERWEIGHT
European Aerospace & Defence	NEUTRAL
Price Target	EUR 220.00
Price (21-Jul-26)	EUR 194.60
Potential Upside/Downside	+13.1%

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

European Aerospace & Defence

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Importantly, Airbus' track record of delivering conservatively framed financial targets suggests investors should view the new medium-term guidance as a floor, with a high degree of confidence that actual outcomes could prove better over time. The tone was also noticeably more constructive on industrial execution and supply chain readiness than six months ago, **reinforcing confidence that the focus of the investment case is shifting from ramp-up execution to medium-term earnings power and shareholder returns**.

While the 2029 EBIT framework broadly met our expectations, the mix is slightly different. Management's implied widebody profit contribution is somewhat lower than we had anticipated, reflecting continued headwinds from A350 launch customer contracts and the A350F ramp. However, this also highlights the significant earnings opportunity that remains beyond the current planning horizon, with management explicitly describing the A350 profitability "sweet spot" as a story for the 2030s. This is offset by a stronger-than-expected contribution from the A320 family than we had anticipated.

Here is what we learned a Business Update:

The narrative has shifted from building capacity to extracting value from previous investments: Management's tone was notably focused on execution and that the industrial system is now increasingly ready to capitalize on the demand. All ten A320 final assembly lines are now operational and A321-capable, Spirit AeroSystems assets have been integrated, and supply chain conditions are improving.

New 2029 EBIT target points to ~15% EBIT CAGR. Growth is expected to be driven primarily by Commercial Aircraft, where EBIT is targeted to increase from €5.5bn to ~€10bn by 2029. This was the most closely watched element of the business update and is broadly consistent with how investors expected Airbus to frame its medium-term guidance. The framework is based on a €/$ exchange rate assumption of 1.22, with management indicating that each one-cent movement in the exchange rate impacts EBIT by approximately €250mn. Beyond Commercial Aircraft,

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Airbus expects Defence & Space EBIT to increase from €0.8bn to ~€1.3bn, supported by the ongoing turnaround in Space and a favourable defence spending environment, while Helicopters is expected to grow EBIT from €0.9bn to ~€1.2bn.

A350 remains an important upside option. Management increasingly acknowledges that the industry could remain structurally short of widebody capacity even once currently planned A350 and 787 production rates are achieved, a view we share. Reflecting this backdrop, Airbus is evaluating production above the currently announced A350 rate of 12 aircraft per month, with a decision potentially before year-end. At the same time, management confirmed that studies on a stretched A350 remain ongoing. The current A350 final assembly line is effectively fully utilized at rate 12, suggesting that any further increase in production would likely require additional industrial investment.

A350 profitability remains a story for the next decade. Management highlighted that the programme's profitability "sweet spot" sits beyond 2029, with 2029 margins still impacted by A350F learning curve and launch customer contracts. As these factors roll off, the A350 should become an increasingly important profit contributor in the next decade.

Services becoming a more material earnings contributor. Airbus aims to almost double Services revenue to $10bn by 2030 while delivering double-digit profitability.

Defence & Space Increasingly Important to the Equity Story. While Commercial Aircraft remains the primary driver of Airbus' medium-term earnings growth, management highlighted that Defence & Space should also make a growing contribution. Following several years of restructuring, Airbus indicated that the Space turnaround is running ahead of plan, while the broader Defence business is well positioned to benefit from rising European defence spending. Growth is expected to be driven by higher MRTT production, a ramp-up in Eurofighter output from around 10 aircraft today to more than 20 by 2028, expansion in drones and collaborative combat aircraft, growing demand for integrated air and missile defence solutions, and the potential creation of a space joint venture with Thales and Leonardo.

Next-Generation Narrowbody Launch Still Targeted ~2030. Airbus reiterated that a next-generation narrowbody remains targeted for launch by the end of the decade, with entry into service planned for the second half of the 2030s. Both open-rotor and conventional engine architectures remain under evaluation.

A meaningful step-up in shareholder returns. Airbus announced an unexpected €5bn share buyback, alongside a 30-50% dividend payout ratio, underpinning management's ambition to return approximately 60% of cumulative FCF to shareholders over 2026-29. In our view, the announcement brings Airbus' capital allocation framework more in line with leading aerospace peers.

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Primary Stocks (Ticker, Date, Price)
Airbus (AIR.PA, 21-Jul-2026, EUR 194.60), Overweight/Neutral, A/CD/D/E/J/K/L/M/N

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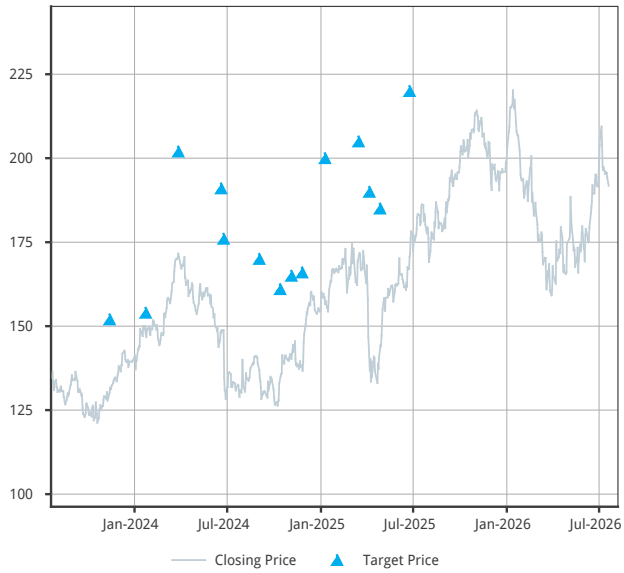
Airbus (AIR FP / AIR.PA)

Stock Rating: **OVERWEIGHT**

Industry View: **NEUTRAL**

Closing Price: **EUR 194.60** (21-Jul-2026)

Rating and Price Target Chart (as of 21-Jul-2026)



Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Link to Barclays Live for interactive charting

Publication Date	Closing Price*	Rating	Adjusted Price Target	Currency
24-Jun-2025	170.60		220.00	EUR
27-Apr-2025	140.60		185.00	EUR
06-Apr-2025	158.02		190.00	EUR
16-Mar-2025	169.20		205.00	EUR
09-Jan-2025	156.58		200.00	EUR
25-Nov-2024	137.94		166.00	EUR
04-Nov-2024	140.28		165.00	EUR
13-Oct-2024	132.92		161.00	EUR
02-Sep-2024	138.82		170.00	EUR
24-Jun-2024	148.78		176.00	EUR
19-Jun-2024	148.12		191.00	EUR
27-Mar-2024	170.12		202.00	EUR
23-Jan-2024	148.00		154.00	EUR
13-Nov-2023	128.48		152.00	EUR

On 21-Jul-2023, prior to any intra-day change that may have been published, the rating for this security was Overweight, and the adjusted price target was 151.00 EUR.

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

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